

# The Architecture of *Grace*

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*Visual Anchor Charts*

*Autism-Adapted Edition · Teacher Supplement*

**BOOK ONE · THE FOUNDATION**

**GRADES K · 1 · 2 · LOWER SUPPORT**

VISUAL-FIRST · CO-REGULATION · TRAUMA-INFORMED

*Fourteen printable anchor charts · one per page*

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PILOT VERSION · 2026-2027 · CONFIDENTIAL

# Before You Begin

*What changed, what didn't, and why*

This supplement is not a new curriculum. It is the same fourteen anchor charts from *Architecture of Grace · Book One · The Foundation*, rebuilt by a multidisciplinary team — autism specialist, school psychologist, school social worker, special education teacher, speech-language pathologist, and occupational therapist — with autistic learners with lower support needs held as the design audience from the first line.

## What did NOT change

- Every defined construct — *Grace, Forgiveness, Trust, Mercy, Oops* vs. *"I Am Bad," Kind Coach, Grumpy Gus, Sammy* — appears exactly as the curriculum defines it.
- The theoretical foundation — Brown's shame/guilt research, Neff's self-compassion, Enright & Fitzgibbons' forgiveness model, Worthington's REACH — is preserved.
- The pedagogy — Sammy as relational anchor, anchor charts built WITH students, Family Connection, Disclosure Protocol — is unchanged.

## What is new in every chart

- **A literal-language anchor.** Each metaphor is also stated plainly, so a child who processes language literally has a foothold into the lesson.
- **Body-first interoception scaffolding** on every emotion-related chart. *Where do I feel it?* precedes *What does it mean?*
- **Scripted sentence frames printed visibly on the chart** — reducing in-the-moment language production load.
- **A Specialist Note** at the bottom of each chart, written to the teacher about what to watch for, what to honor, and what to never force.

## One protective addition, in two places

The Pause Practice (U4 · L3) and the Forgiveness vs. Trust chart (U3 · L3) carry an added line each: a pattern-tracking guardrail. Autistic children are statistically more likely to be bullied and disbelieved; the original "choose the kind story" framing — without this guardrail — can train a child to override accurate threat detection. The construct is unchanged. The guardrail is new.

### A NOTE ON LANGUAGE

"Level 1," "mild-to-moderate," "high-functioning," and "lower support needs" all describe the same population. We use *lower support needs* in this edition, in line with current clinical and self-advocate consensus. No child's support needs are static — a child who looks Level 1 at recess may need Level 2 support in a fire drill. Design accordingly.

# My Identity Web

Who I Am — All the Pieces of Me

Build one branch at a time · Each branch is a different part of who you are

★ ★ ★

BRANCH 1 — Things I LOVE

my favorite people, animals, foods, places, things to do  
*special interests count — write them BIG*

★ ★ ★

MY NAME

*write in center*

★ ★ ★

BRANCH 2 — Things I'm GOOD AT

what I can do, what I'm learning  
*even small things count*

BRANCH 3 — Things I CARE ABOUT

people, animals, ideas, fairness  
*caring a LOT about something is okay*

BRANCH 4 — Things That Make Me FEEL GOOD

music, soft things, quiet, movement, my person  
*this is your branch — no wrong answers*

BRANCH 5 — Still LEARNING

what I want to get better at  
*"learning" is not the same as "bad at"*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Branch 4 (originally "My SPECIAL Thing") has been renamed *Things That Make Me FEEL GOOD* — this opens space for sensory regulators (a favorite texture, a quiet corner, stim toys, a specific song) to be named as part of identity, not as something separate or weird. *Special interests in Branch 1 should be welcomed at full intensity — these are not distractions from identity; they are identity.* Build one branch at a time. Post BEFORE the worksheet. Keep posted all year.

# Feelings Are Messengers

*First I find it in my body · Then I name it · Then I listen*

*Feelings are not problems. Feelings are information about what is happening inside us.*

## THREE STEPS · IN ORDER

**1. Where in my body do I feel it? · 2. What is its name? · 3. What does my body need now?**

### HAPPY

*often: warm chest · easy breath · wanting to move*

Something good is happening. I am safe.

### SAD

*often: heavy chest · wet eyes · tired arms*

Something I care about was lost or hurt. I might need a hug or a quiet space.

### ANGRY

*often: hot face · tight hands · loud chest*

Something feels unfair. I might need help, or space, or to move.

### SCARED

*often: fast heart · cold belly · wanting to be small*

Something feels unsafe. My body wants to keep me safe.

### OVERWHELMED · TOO MUCH

*often: noisy head · tight chest · everything is loud or bright*

There is too much coming in. I need less — fewer sounds, fewer people, a break.

### PROUD

*often: tall back · warm face · wanting to show someone*

I did something hard. I worked through it.

## SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Many autistic children have *interoception differences* — the inside-the-body sense that delivers feeling-data is quieter or differently mapped. The original chart asks “*What is this feeling trying to tell me?*” — a question that requires the body signal to arrive first. We added the body-first step ahead of naming. Some children will say “*I don’t feel it anywhere*” — that is honest data, not non-compliance. Accept it. Over time, naming where it *isn’t* often makes room for noticing where it *is*. The “OVERWHELMED · TOO MUCH” card is new and essential — it is not a moral failure; it is a sensory load report.